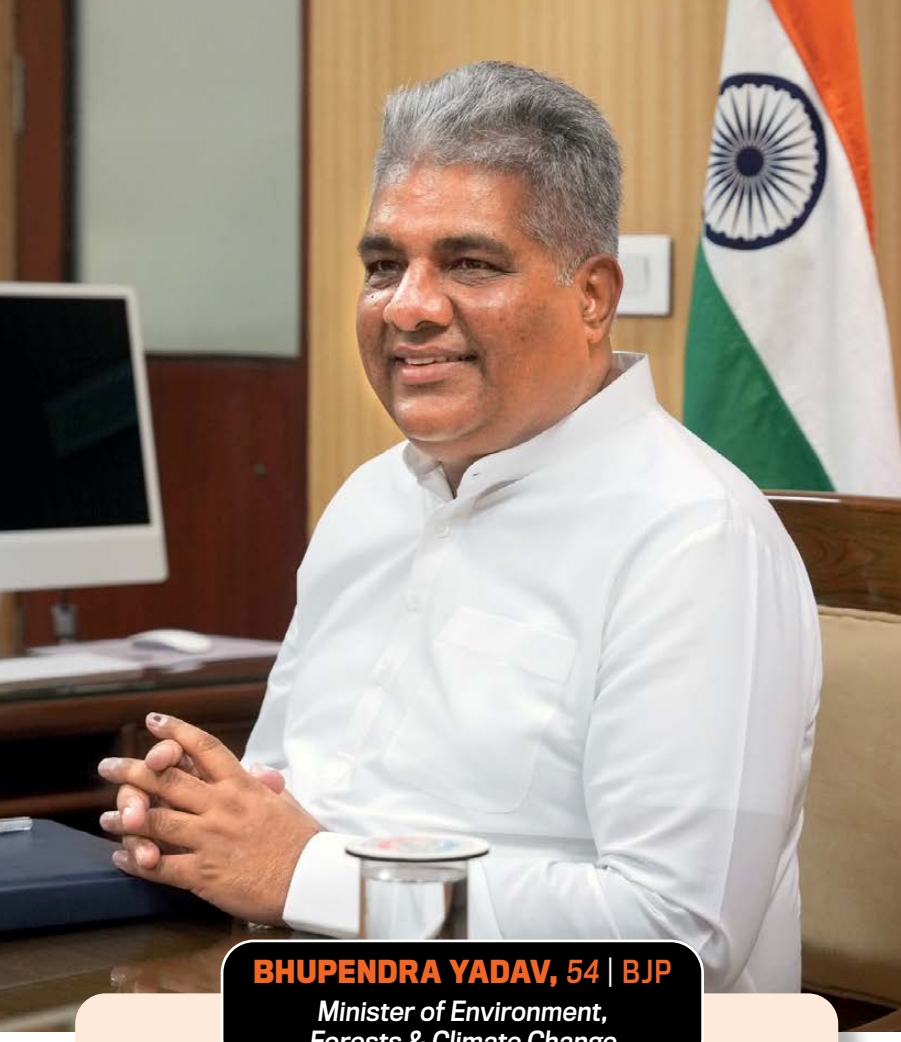


BHUPENDRA YADAV, *54* | BJP

Minister of Environment, Forests & Climate Change

With the law Born in Ajmer, Bhupendra Yadav is a lawyer by training. After joining student politics, he worked with the RSS and was later drafted into the BJP. Before joining politics, he was an advocate in the Supreme Court

Coordinating polls Yadav was elected to the Rajya Sabha in 2012 and is often part of the BJP's central team of coordinators. He has been heading the environment ministry since 2021

Letting the Cheetah in It was in his tenure as environment minister that the cheetah introduction programme was initiated in 2022. Under his watch, there has also been an increase in tiger and snow leopard numbers due to conservation efforts

Big Cat Alliance In February 2024, the Union Cabinet approved setting up the International Big Cat Alliance (IBCA)—aiming to conserve the world's big cats—with headquarters in India with a one-time budgetary support of Rs 150 crore from 2023-24 to 2027-28

Author, author Yadav is author of two books, *Rise of the BJP* and *Supreme Court on Forest Conservation*

Minister of State

KIRTI VARDHAN SINGH, *58* | BJP

Five-time MP from Gonda, UP; also MoS of external affairs

bound, comprehensive plan to address the root cause is required

AMEND LAWS, BUT CAREFULLY

Many experts saw amendments to key legislations like the Biodiversity Act, the Wildlife Protection Act and the Forest Conservation Act as a dilution of guaranteed protection. India's gains in wildlife and forestry flow from these laws. Any changes should be based on genuine feedback from all stakeholders. Forests, environment and wildlife should not be seen as hurdles in development

MAINTAINING PARKS

Protected Areas (Sanctuaries and National Parks) need to be sacrosanct. The propensity to denotify parts of these amounts to an attack on our heritage

A STRIPED BALANCE

Man-animal conflict is on the rise. A detailed approach to solving this issue through out-of-the-box thinking based on international experiences is required

EYE ON EMISSIONS

India has achieved its targets that were submitted as part of the nationally determined contributions during the Paris climate talks in 2015. But it needs to keep its eyes on the eventual goal—achieving net zero emissions by 2070

ASSESS UJJWALA

An analysis of the Ujjwala Yojana—which provides LPG connections to BPL households—is needed to see if it led to reduction in use of timber as fuel in villages near forests. If not, more non-timber fuel can be given to such communities